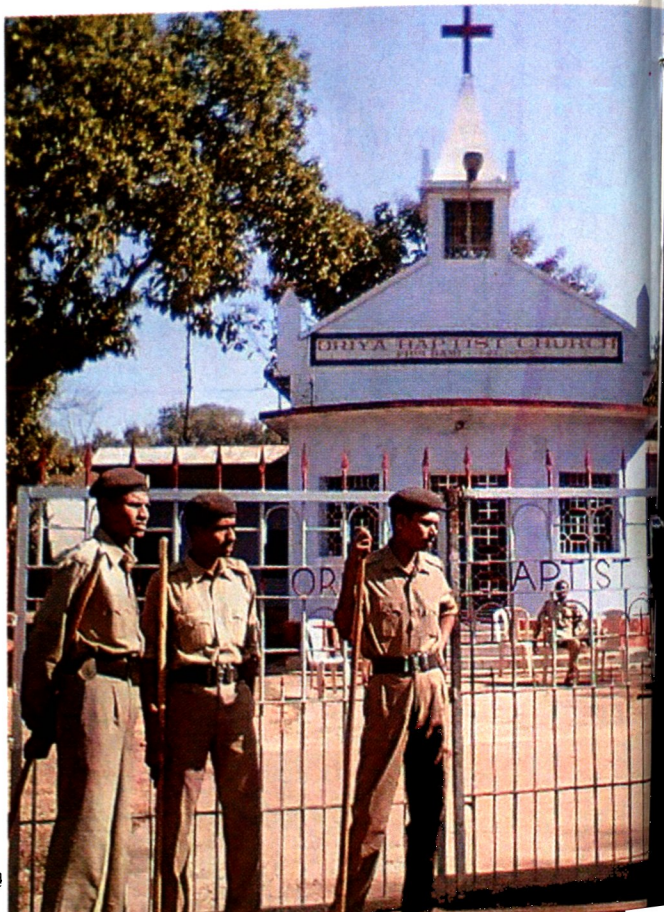


FAITH ATTACK

Communal tension grips Orissa again after churches are torched and charges traded between groups



UNHOLY SPELL: Christians protest (above); lax security (right)

Christmas is usually a season of good cheer. Not so for the over one lakh Christians of Orissa's tribal-dominated Kandhamal district as simmering communal tension reached a flashpoint turning their celebrations into a tragedy. What began as a dispute between local Christians and Hindus over the erection of welcome arches for the festivities at Brahmanigaon village on the eve of Christmas, snowballed into a major conflagration the next day. Mobs damaged three churches and vandalised 12 others, also targeting minority-run schools and institutions.

With the state police apparently ill-prepared to deal with the violence, one person was killed and more than 24 sustained injuries in clashes which occurred in several parts of the district. The state administration was forced to impose curfew in the troubled zones to restore peace. The violence coincided with a Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) sponsored bandh called to protest the attack on Swami Laxmananand Saraswati, a social worker, while he was on his way to Brahmanigaon vil-



lage in the wake of clashes the previous day. VHP state general secretary Gouri Prasad Rath says Laxmananand sustained injuries on his head and face when miscreants, allegedly from the Christian community, stopped his vehicle and beat him up.

However, Christian leaders insist that the "reign of terror" was unleashed by VHP and Bajrang Dal workers who led the bandh from the front. "It was a terrible night. With armed goons roaming the streets we could not move out of our houses, let alone celebrate Christmas," said Arup Jena, president, Oriya Baptist Church, Phulbani, and joint secretary of the All Orissa United Christian Forum.

The spate of violence subsided only the next day after over 23 platoons of armed reserve police were rushed to the district. But the police are to blame for not taking preventive measures earlier. With the battlelines drawn between Christian missionaries and the Hindutva brigade, the district remains communally sensitive. The clash between members of the two communi-

ties at Brahmanigaon on December 24 should have alerted the police, especially with VHP giving a bandh call.

Christian activists charge Laxmananand with having a hand in several attacks against churches and missionaries in the past few years. "The atmosphere of hatred has been building up slowly," says Jena. Laxmananand refutes the allegations and points an accusing finger at Rajya Sabha MP, Radha Kant Nayak, a Christian, for engineering the attack on him. "They wanted to turn the entire area into a Christian belt but people like me are an obstacle. Therefore I have been attacked," Laxmananand claimed. But Nayak denied his involvement in the incident.

Given that the killing of missionary Graham Staines had also taken place in Orissa, there has been concern about violence spreading to other parts of the state. Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik has appealed to the people to maintain calm. But for the communities to feel secure, the state will have to take proactive measures to keep the peace.

by Ashutosh Mishra